the deployment of the old Soviet energy infrastructure (especially pipelines) to strengthen and extend Moscow's international standing – energy seen as the 'geopolitical weapon'.

Putin pursued his reforms while aiding, and being aided by, the political ascendancy of the so-called *siloviki*, a term which refers to a political clan whose members originated in the KGB/FSB universe. The usefulness of this label is contested (see for instance Renz 2006), but broadly the *siloviki* were nationalist in outlook, and keen to restore the strength and security of the Russian state, seeing Russia's natural-resource wealth as central in obtaining this goal. The term *siloviki* also included those among Putin's allies and associates whose political or business careers took off somewhere within the old KGB apparatus. Another powerful group, known as the Leningrad faction and exemplified by such prominent figures as Alexei Miller (CEO of Gazprom), or Dmitrii Medvedev himself (Gazprom's Chairman of the Board of Directors since June 2002, before he became Russian President in 2008), was made up of men mostly born in the 1950s and 1960s, who at one point or another would have met Putin when he was cutting his political teeth as head of the city administration's Committee of External Relations. The Gazprom City project thus represented the fusion of authoritarianism and corporatism which characterises Russia's version of neoliberal capitalism (see Ilarionov 2006; Wood 2007; Pirani 2010; and Dawisha 2014; for the specific role of Gazprom see Rosner 2005; Lucas 2008, 35–38; Benton and Buckley 2008; and Sixmith 2010).

But whatever the contrast with Yeltsin, Putin's ascent to the Kremlin represented a consolidation and a recomposition of the Russian ruling class; it was not, as has sometimes been argued, a comeback of the state against the economic elite and, equally, not a bureaucratic crackdown against the first generation of Russian oligarchs, the almighty Berezovskis and Gusinskis of the 1990s. This is true even of his own outlook. Putin is a product of the Soviet Union, of its cynical and pragmatic attitudes towards official ideology; and he is also a product of the Soviet defeat by international capitalism and the humiliation and trauma of the 'transition' to the market. In this worldview, shared by many in the generation which now controls the country, regaining lost Russian greatness means beating capitalists at their own game. As Gleb Pavlosky (until 2011 a close adviser to the President) has put it: 'Putin's idea is that we should be bigger and better capitalists than the capitalists, and be more consolidated as a state: there should be maximum oneness of state and business' (Pavlovsky 2014:57).

The point, then, is that the transformation of Russian politics and society since 1991 has largely revolved around three interrelated elements. Firstly, it